AI FOR AFRICA

FROM STRATEGY TO INCLUSIVE IMPACT

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Africa is at a crucial turning point. Artificial intelligence (AI) has slowly progressed beyond experimental stages. It is now integrated into national strategies, corporate investments, and operational deployments. This transformation is directly impacting health, agriculture, and financial services across the continent. Guiding these changes is the African Union's Continental Artificial Intelligence Strategy (2024), a development-focused blueprint that provides policymakers with a practical framework. This strategy grounds AI within the principles of ethics, inclusion, and regional cooperation.

Opportunities and structural realities

Africa stands on the brink of a significant opportunity, as highlighted by the State of AI in Africa Report 2025. The report gives details about a surge in startup activity, an expansion of pilot programmes across various sectors, and the development of a more sophisticated policy landscape. However, the continent continues to face ongoing challenges, including inconsistent broadband access, unreliable electricity, and a scarcity of skilled engineers and data scientists. These structural issues significantly threaten to concentrate the benefits of this growth in more developed urban centres. Therefore, international collaboration is crucial to prevent technology transfer from leading to dependency rather than genuine local capability, emphasising the need for robust governance and the development of local expertise.

Emerging leaders and practical progress

Significant and demonstrable progress is already evident. For example, Rwanda's National Health Intelligence Center, launched in April 2025, effectively gathers real-time health data. This supports epidemic preparedness, optimises resource allocation, and provides AI-assisted clinical decision support, showcasing how national platforms can have the capability to significantly boost public health impact.

Nigeria's National Artificial Intelligence Strategy (2024) is an example of a governance-first approach, outlining objectives for skills development, research funding, and ethical oversight. This model is now influencing similar initiatives in Kenya and Ghana.

This policy momentum is further enhanced by private investment. Major technology companies are starting to expand regional cloud and AI capabilities, while also committing to large-scale training programmes. Microsoft's multi-million-rand investment in South Africa's AI infrastructure, along with continent-wide training pledges, illustrates the collaborative potential of public and private sectors in building capacity and human capital.



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Policy and investment priorities for G20 and BRICS

For G20 and BRICS nations, the urgent policy recommendation is to integrate infrastructure, governance, and human capital.

To securely and affordably host and train AI models, African institutions require blended finance that is directed towards regional compute hubs and resilient energy networks. Endorsing the AU's Continental AI Strategy will serve as a unifying framework for data protection, model audits, and cross-border collaboration, thereby reducing fragmentation and enhancing trust.

Scaling accredited training and apprenticeship programmes is crucial. Certification programmes that link government hiring, corporate procurement, and university research will ground AI ecosystems in local talent, rather than relying on imported expertise.

From vision to implementation

To effectively implement these priorities, practical pilot programmes and responsible financial backing are essential. Collaborative health and agricultural testbeds that mandate local data management, clear evaluation, and open results will establish national models ready for widespread adoption. Development banks, corporate collaborators, and BRICS technical agencies should mitigate the risks of initial deployments through favourable lending and procurement strategies that guarantee skills development and demonstrable social impact.

Africa's AI future

Action is critical now. An achievable package for upcoming summits includes regional compute nodes, scholarship and certification funds, and three co-funded national testbeds. If G20 and BRICS nations align funding with governance and human capital, Africa can shape and govern AI for inclusive development, rather than merely adopting it. Coordinated, deliberate action within the next year will determine if AI propels the continent towards shared prosperity and resilience.